

Win at losing

No, I'm not talking about losing weight here, as most others who use that phrase generally mean. What I mean is learning from our mistakes, building character, and all of that... Everyone is good at winning, it's when you're losing that your mettle shows. Real winners have almost always lost a great deal during the course of life, and it's what makes them successful. However, I don't mean for this to become a random, generic rant. I'm being specific about technology, and the way we interface with it.

I recently met a friend who was complaining that his Nexus 7 just stopped working. As a fellow owner of the device, I've had some experience with dropping it and the battery coming loose, and then the battery connector getting dislodged. What did I do when my Nexus 7 died? I did a quick search on YouTube to see if there was any special trick to popping it open, and when I learnt that there was none, I opened it up, saw the loose connector, reconnected, booted up, ensured all was well, snapped the back cover in place again – about 15 to 20 minutes of tinkering, and my tablet was as good as new.

When I told him to do this, he said he'd rather give it to the service centre. It's only after I insisted that he let me open it, with reassurances that I'd use my clout (I have none, believe me, I was bluffing) to get him a new Nexus if something went wrong. Turns out it was the same problem, and was sorted in 15 minutes (no YouTube video to watch this time) – the device was as good as new.

This is the problem with technology today. We just don't lose enough to it to get any better at winning with it. People who love Apple usually say it's "Because it just works", and in many ways that's good, but in a few ways it's terrible as far as I'm concerned. I hate not being able to tinker. The only reason I love technology with a passion is because I can tinker. Or at least I was able to, with PCs and the likes, a lot more than with all these gadgets. I still can with software, but I'm pathetic with code.

Thus I find myself happily voiding warranty, rooting, jailbreaking, etc., because it's *my* device, I paid for it; or even if it came for testing, I am willing to pay for it if I ruin it whilst tinkering (and I have ruined and paid for a few over the years).

When it comes to voiding warranty, I won't let some idiotic company dumb me down and turn me into some brain dead robot with a threat of withholding some service just because I'm inquisitive. If I lose money by being a tinkerer, it's OK, it's only money and I can earn more eventually, but I don't want to get soft by not fighting troubleshooting battles and eventually losing the war against idiocy in the bargain.

It's not just troubleshooting, it's also tweaking, understanding the device better and making mistakes. I installed beta and leaked versions of BlackBerry OS 10.3 on my phone a few months ago and corrupted my data. I wasn't able to backup or restore anything to the phone and had to format it. I lost about 10 days of SMSes, some contacts, and other random data (the new stuff since my last successful backup). I'm still going to continue to try beta or even alpha software, I'll just backup more often when using it... lesson learnt!

Losing to technology is always, only temporary, and that's the beauty of it. I've been getting my @\$\$ kicked by some problems on the forum for months now. I've narrowed it down to the forum software not playing well with our server configuration. Those of you on the forum will know the file upload and IP problems I'm referring to. Like I said, technology is winning right now, and I'm losing miserably, but sooner or later I will triumph, and will have reduced the ways tech can beat me in the future by one.

I know I'm preaching to the choir, because Digit readers by definition are tinkerers, but I just wanted to make sure to remind you to keep trying new things and not fear losing. With technology, losing initially is the only true path to winning eventually. So, get out there and start losing to technology every now and then, or else you're not trying to win hard enough. 



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